HCP 1171 (cpc_1915-11-22_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-06): a Hungarian thank-you card with a coded greeting and signature

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

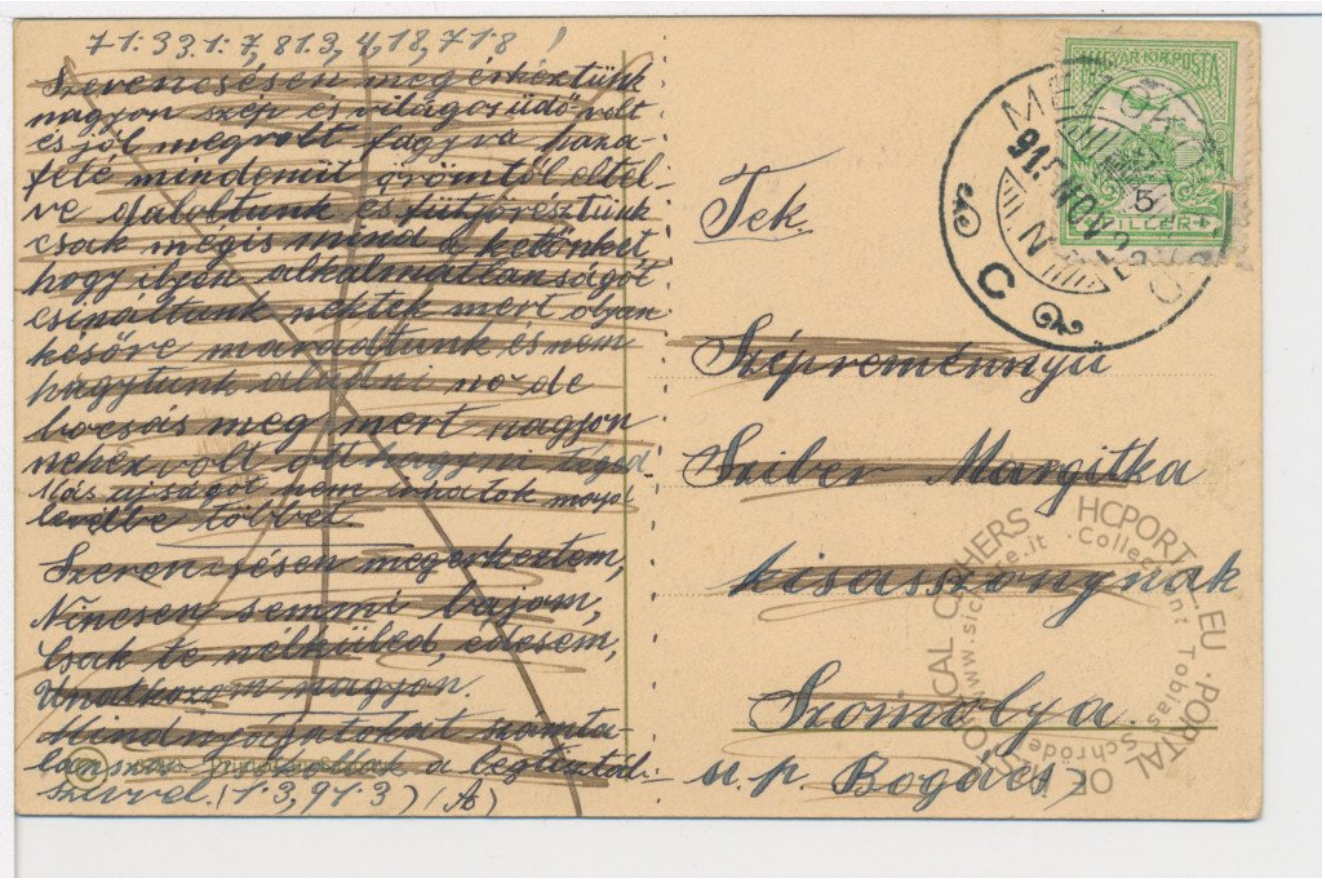
Status: all 20 cipher signs are deciphered with a key transferred unchanged from a sister card; the open text is read in full, with one thinly legible word; independent review 1 verdict ACCEPT, seven minor findings addressed, cipher reading unchanged. Report dated 2026-11-02.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1171 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1171), portal name cpc_1915-11-22_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-06, from Tobias Schrödel's cryptographic postcards collection (private collection). When captured on 2026-11-02 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, category Substitution, language Unknown, sender Unknown, recipient Margitka Sziber, with no transcription or solution attached. The portal links a HistoCrypt article (https://ecp.ep.liu.se/index.php/histocrypt/article/view/166). That article was **not checked** for this card, so it is not known whether it treats it. No published solution was used.

The picture side shows a tinted portrait of a young woman, printed sideways on the scan, and carries no writing. All the writing is on the address side. The address reads **Tek. / Szépreménnyu / Sziber Margitka / kisasszonynak / Szomolya / u. p. Bogács**, that is, to the promising young lady Margitka Sziber at Szomolya, post office Bogács, in north-east Hungary. Szépreménnyu is given as written; the normal form is szépreményű, and other cards in the series also double the n. The 5-fillér stamp is cancelled 915 NOV 2?, with the second digit of the day not clear. Only the M of the town name is legible, so Mezőkövesd is inferred from the series. The portal file name gives 1915-11-22.

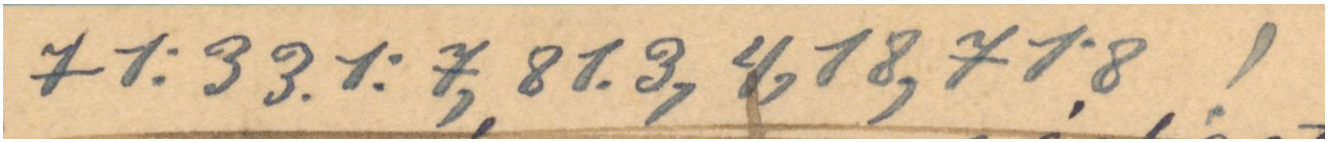
The card belongs to the wartime correspondence from Mezőkövesd to Margitka Sziber at Szomolya (hcp-1135 to 1179). Its message is open Hungarian, later struck through in brown ink by an unknown hand. Only the salutation at the top and the signature in brackets at the foot are enciphered, as a row of digits with marks.



Message and address side (source/address-large.jpg)



Picture side, no writing (source/picture-large.jpg)



Enciphered top line, enlarged (review/work/top.png)



Foot of the card with the enciphered signature in brackets and the open (A), enlarged (review/work/sig.png)

Method

The transcription is manual, from the un-converted high-resolution scan enlarged 3 to 4 times. No OCR was used. To see the open text under the brown strike-outs, the red channel of the scan was used, which removes most of the brown and keeps the blue writing. The one word lying over the printed publisher line was isolated by colour.

No key was built here. The key was taken unchanged from FINAL card hcp-1174 of the same correspondence, where it was reconstructed. That makes this card a fixed test of that key: 20 of 20 signs decode, with no adjustment, to two exact words and a name. There are 13 distinct signs, and each is already in the sister key. The reviewer decoded the same signs independently by parsing the key tables of hcp-1174 and hcp-1178, and found no conflict between those two cards.

Key

Monoalphabetic substitution, register label MASC. A digit and its mark together are one sign. Only the signs that occur on this card are listed; the fuller table is on hcp-1174.

Sign	Letter	Sign	Letter	Sign	Letter
1	i	3	d	7	k
1.	a	3,	r	7,	s
1:	e	3.	v	8	m
1' (high dot)	á	4,	g	8,	t
9	p				

The ciphertext, 20 signs in all:

```
Top line:          7 1: 3 3. 1: 7,  8 1. 3, 4, 1 8, 7 1' 8 !
                   = Kedves Margitkám!
Foot, in brackets: ( 1' 3, 9 1' 3 )
                   = Árpád
```

Plaintext

Hungarian, as on the card; **bold** marks the enciphered words, everything else is open writing. Commas in the prose are editorial, as the card has none there.

Kedves Margitkám!

Szerencsésen megérkeztünk, nagyon szép és világos üdő volt és jól megvolt fagyva, hazafelé mindenüt örömtől eltelve daloltunk és fütyörésztünk, csak mégis mind a kettőnket hogy ilyen alkalmatlanságot csináltunk nektek, mert olyan későre maradtunk és nem hagytunk aludni, no de bocsás meg, mert nagyon nehéz volt ott hagyni téged. Más ujságot nem irhatok majd levélbe többet.

Szerencsésen megérkeztem, / Nincsen semmi bajom, / Csak te nélküled, édesem, / Unatkozom nagyon.

Mindnyájatokat számtalanszor csókollak a legtiszták szivvel. (**Árpád**) (A)

The writer's spellings differ from the normal forms: üdő = idő, mindenüt = mindenütt, bocsás = bocsáss, legtiszták = legtisztább, szivvel = szívvel, ujságot = újságot, irhatok = írhatok.

English translation: Dear Margitka! We arrived safely. The weather was very fine and clear and it was well frozen; on the way home, filled with joy everywhere, we sang and whistled. Only still, the two of us [regret: verb unwritten] that we caused you such inconvenience, because we stayed so late and did not let you sleep. Well, forgive me, because it was very hard to leave you. I cannot write any more news, later in a letter.

I have arrived safely, / nothing is wrong with me, / only without you, my sweet, / I am very bored.

I kiss you all countless times with the purest heart. (Árpád) (A)

Slovak translation: Milá Margitka! Šťastne sme dorazili. Počasie bolo veľmi pekné a jasné a dobre primrzlo; cestou domov, všade naplnení radosťou, sme spievali a pohvizdovali. Len predsa nás oboch [mrzí: sloveso nie je napísané], že sme vám spôsobili takú nepríjemnosť, lebo sme zostali tak dlho a nenechali sme vás spať. No odpusť mi, lebo bolo veľmi ťažké ťa opustiť. Ďalšie novinky nemôžem napísať, viac potom v liste.

Šťastne som dorazil, / nič mi nechýba, / len bez teba, moja sladká, / sa veľmi nudím.

Všetkých vás nespočetnekrát bozkávam s najčistejším srdcom. (Árpád) (A)

The situation is coherent: a late evening visit, an apology for keeping the household awake, and a walk home over frozen ground in late November. The quatrain rhymes (megérkeztem / édesem, bajom / nagyon).

Reproduction

From the repository root:

```
python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1171/work/decode.py
```

The script uses only the Python standard library. It checks the SHA-256 hashes of all four scans, decodes the 20 signs with the key, asserts each word and prints the card. The open text is hard-coded, so the command tests the decoding of the cipher signs only, not the reading of the handwriting.

Uncertainties

The cipher has no doubtful sign. The brown strike-out crosses the lower stem of the `4,`, but its hook is visible. All the points below concern the open text.

- **csókollak** is the least sure word. It lies across the printed publisher line and the strike-out. The end -k-o-l-l-a-k is clear; the opening c-s-ó shows three letters of the right widths with the hooked foot of an s, but those letters are not independently legible. The sentence and the same verb on hcp-1174 support it. The accent on ó is not seen. With a plural object (Mindnyájatokat) the form is normal, as -lak covers "you all".
- **Missing verb.** `csak mégis mind a kettőnket / hogy ilyen ...` has no main verb on the card; a verb like bántja ("troubles") is understood. All the words are read and the gap is the writer's, so this is not an unread clause. The translations mark the supplied verb.
- **The a of mind a** is blotted and may be overwritten; a descender from the row above and a brown stroke run into it. `mind a kettőnket` is the only idiomatic reading, so this letter rests on word sense.
- **legtiszták** has one b, followed by a hyphen under the line end, before szivvel on the next row. The final letters run into the strike-out and the green margin rule. The missing b is read as a slip.
- **Más** has an open initial that could look like another capital; the word fits what follows.
- **levélbe többet** follows majd at a line end. "Later in a letter" is a free rendering of literally "more ... then in a letter".

- **(A)** after the signature is in clear and not explained. It is likely his initial: hcp-1179 is signed Sz. A., although that card's solution notes the pixels there also allow Sz. K., and hcp-1175 reads Sz. A. It may be Á; no accent is seen.
- The postmark town is inferred, and the second digit of the day is faint.
- It is not known who struck the text through, or when, or whether the linked HistoCrypt article discusses this card.

Review summary

Reviewer: Claude Opus 5.5 (Anthropic), a separate agent, round 1, verdict **ACCEPT**. The reviewer ran the command, decoded the signs with its own script from sister-card key tables and its own crops, checked every sign and every row of open text on the high-resolution scan, and examined the difficult places with its own colour separation. Its seven findings were all minor and are addressed:

- **Address word.** Szépreményű corrected to Szépreménnyu as written, with the normal form given. This is the only change to the transcribed text.
- **Brackets.** The editorial legtisztáb[b] was removed, since brackets marked enciphered text in the working solution.
- **Translation notes.** Two notes pointing to an implied word were deleted; no word is implied there.
- **The a of mind a.** Now described in full and stated to rest on word sense.
- **(A).** The thin stroke before it is the opening bracket, the same shape as the bracket before the enciphered name, and the hcp-1179 signature is cited.
- **Postmark town.** Now stated as inferred, as only M is legible.
- **Dots in the signature.** The claim that they stand lower was withdrawn, and the Arpad alternative with it.

No cipher sign or decoded word changed as a result of the review. The transcription, key transfer and decipherment were made by Claude Opus 5.5; there was no earlier work on this number.

Sources

- HC Portal record 1171, General, Description and Attachments tabs, captured 2026-11-02: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1171 (source/metadata.md).
- Picture side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3573/conversions/cpc_1915-11-22_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-06_pic-large.jpg (source/picture-large.jpg); un-converted original in work/hires/.
- Address side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3574/conversions/cpc_1915-11-22_HU_Mezokovesd_HU_Szomolya_szomolya-06_adr-large.jpg (source/address-large.jpg); un-converted original in work/hires/.
- Key: FINAL card hcp-1174 in this repository, also hcp-1178; correspondence comparison with hcp-1140, 1152, 1175 and 1179.
- AI Decipherment Register (https://ai.hcportal.eu/register/), checked 2026-11-02 by the orchestrator: no record for this card.